



LUMON INDUSTRIES

HANDBOOK FOR THE SEVERED EMPLOYEE

Macrodata Refinement Division · Orientation, Conduct & Compliance

DOC. NO. LUM-MDR-0047 · REV. 12
OFFICE OF CULTURE & COMPLIANCE · KIER, PE
EFFECTIVE 09.19.2026

PRAISE KIER

*they gave me this on my first day. I
believed every word. — P.*

LUM-MDR-0047 · REV. 12

DOCUMENT CONTROL

PROPERTY OF LUMON INDUSTRIES

This handbook is issued to one refiner and one refiner only. If found outside the severed floor, return it to Optics & Design at once. Do not copy it. Do not lend it. Do not memorize it incorrectly.

REVISION HISTORY

REV.	DATE	CHANGE
12	09.19.2026	Routine calibration of Chapters 4-5. Perk illustrations refreshed.
11	02.03.2026	Wellness questionnaire expanded (see Ch. 4).
10	11.20.2025	Chapter 12 removed at the Board's request. Do not ask about Chapter 12.
9	06.14.2025	Finger-trap illustration updated. The finger traps are now blue.
8	01.30.2025	Compunction Statement, 14th printing. No changes to the words.

HOW TO USE THIS HANDBOOK

Read each chapter in order. Complete the Intake Form in ink. If a procedure confuses you, that is the procedure working. Your supervisor is available for all questions except the forbidden ones, which you will not ask.

This handbook is issued as the basis document of SEVERANCE PRIMED, a Cortex Prime tabletop game built on Eagan's Nine Principles. Requires the Cortex Prime Game Handbook. 3-5 players + one GM. The work is hard and important.

*IF YOU FOUND THIS
COPY IT'S MINE. I
WROTE IN IT. SORRY.
NOT SORRY. - P.*

CHAPTER 01

WELCOME, REFINER

“THE WORK IS MYSTERIOUS AND IMPORTANT.”

— ATTRIBUTED TO KIER EAGAN

Congratulations, refiner. You have been selected — from among many qualified candidates, and from among the hours of your own life — to serve Lumon Industries on the severed floor. This handbook contains everything your innie needs to know. Your outie has already read the other one.

You are one of Lumon's severed workers: people who agreed to have their memories surgically divided, so that the self who clocks in never knows the self who clocks out. By day you refine mysterious numbers in a windowless room. By night — in brief, stolen interludes — you glimpse the outie whose life paid for yours. Lumon calls the arrangement a gift. The Nine Principles say what you must become to deserve it.

WHAT THIS HANDBOOK IS

Genre, reverse-engineered: corporate dystopia × paranoid espionage thriller × religious cult drama. On the fantastic–realistic axis the game sits almost entirely on the realistic side: one science-fictional element (the severance chip) in an otherwise present-day world of fluorescent offices, company towns, and middle management. The horror is bureaucratic, not cosmic.

none of this is true. all of it is true. — P.

Theme: who owns a self — the person who suffers, or the company that bought the suffering? Every procedure in this handbook asks the same question two ways: what will you surrender to belong, and what will you risk to remember?

Mood: sterile, uncanny, retro-futurist dread — long fluorescent hallways, cheerful posters, a waffle party that feels like a threat — punctured by small, fierce human warmth: a shared joke in MDR, a map drawn from memory, a book passed hand to hand. Play it straight. Let the comedy come from the doctrine, never from the people.

The protagonists are severed workers — refiners, designers, goat-tenders — with no power except each other and the truth. **The antagonist** is not a person but a system: Lumon Industries, its doctrine, its cameras, its kindness. Named enforcers (Cobel, Milchick) appear as GMCs, but they are the doctrine's hands, not its heart. Per the Cortex heuristics, a system-antagonist means the game's opposition runs on the **Doom Pool** and **Crisis Pools**, not on contests against a faction.

CHAPTER 02

THE NINE PRINCIPLES

“NINE PRINCIPLES. NINE TAILS. ONE PATH.”

— OFFICE OF CULTURE & COMPLIANCE

Kier Eagan gave us nine principles, and the nine principles gave us everything. Study them. Internalize them. They are not rules; they are the shape of a good person. Below, each principle is shown with the virtue it claims, the work it quietly does, and the model statement your supervisor will expect to hear.

Three prime sets, plus Distinctions as always. There are no Attributes, no Skills, no Powers on the severed floor — Lumon hired your hands, not your résumé, and the chip took the rest.

DISTINCTIONS

Three per refiner, each rated **d8** (roll **d4** instead to gain 1 PP, per the standard rule). Severance imposes one structure on them: **one distinction must belong to your outie** (the life outside: *My Outie Buried His Wife on a Tuesday*), **one must belong to your innie** (the life at work: *The Friendliest Refiner on the Floor*), and **one is free** — the self in question, the part of you neither Lumon nor your outie can fully name (*I Laugh When I Shouldn't*).

THE NINE PRINCIPLES (VALUES)

The game's Values set is Kier Eagan's Nine Principles — the doctrine's virtues, each carrying its true function underneath. Every principle is rated **d4**–**d12** and carries a one-line **statement**, written in Kier's liturgical voice or your own. The ratings measure how deeply the innie has internalized the doctrine — not how good they are.

PRINCIPLE	THE VIRTUE IT CLAIMS	THE WORK IT DOES	MODEL STATEMENT
VISION	Clarity of purpose; faith in Kier's path	Suppresses questions; binds you to an unquestionable mission	"Kier's path is the only path worth seeing."
VERVE	Constant energy and enthusiasm	Forces permanent upbeat commitment, even under pressure	"I bring my whole heart to every shift."
WIT	Practical intelligence in service of the company	Values quick thinking — only when aligned with Lumon	"My cleverness belongs to Lumon."
CHEER	Happiness as the default	Enforces mandatory positivity; a facade of well-being	"A smiling refiner is a loyal refiner."

HUMILITY	Submission before Kier's leadership	Turns pride into obedience; self-erasure as virtue	"I am small; Kier is great."
BENEVOLENCE	Courtesy and kindness among colleagues	Masks conflict; preserves harmony, even in abusive settings	"We are all friends here."
NIMBLENESS	Flexibility; resistance-free adaptation	Rewards swift obedience to imposed change	"I bend the way the company bends me."
PROBITY	Moral integrity as total compliance	Treats any disagreement as a character flaw	"To question is to fail."
WILES	Strategy and cunning in pursuit of goals	Justifies manipulation — in the mission's name	"The mission excuses the method."

PRINCIPLES IN PLAY

Uphold. When you act at real cost to honor a principle's statement — smiling through obeying the order that sickens you — step that principle up one die for the rest of the session. Describe the doctrine speaking through you.

Challenge. When you violate a principle to act like a free person — asking the forbidden question, refusing the cheerful mask, turning your wiles against Lumon itself — gain **1 PP**, and the GM steps up the lowest die in the Doom Pool. *Lumon notices.* The waffle party's nine-tailed whip has one tail for each principle; every challenge is a lash the doctrine remembers.

*they're not virtues.
they're a leash. count
the tails. — P.*

RELATIONSHIPS

Two sets, one awake at a time — the severance runs through your people too. This is the **Mutually Exclusive** limit: only the active set's dice can enter a pool. The other set is shut down.

- **Inside** — awake on the severed floor. **d10**: one fellow innie you trust with your real thoughts. **d8**: one more inside figure — a coworker, or Management (Cobel, Milchick, Ms. Casey). Everyone else in here is **d6**.
- **Outside** — shut down while you're innie. **d8**: one key person from your outie's life. Everyone else out there is **d6**. This set comes online during Outie Interludes — and only then, unless something breaks the rules.
- **d8** — **My Outie**: your relationship with your own other self. The one relationship severance can't cut — it is **never shut down**, whichever set is active. Roll it when you act on knowledge only your outie could have, when you defy your outie's wishes, or when the two of you — impossibly — seem to be working together.

MEMORANDUM — THE FLIP

Every severance transition flips the active set **automatically**: elevator down, Inside comes online and Outside shuts down; elevator up, the reverse. The flip itself pays nothing — it's just the premise. The Limit pays **1 PP** when **you** shut down a set, once, at the moment of shutdown: switching sets mid-shift (the Overtime Contingency below), or sitting out a scene without your people (the set restores at the next scene).

Two things break the exclusion. The **Overtime Contingency** flips the set for a scene (below). A **Bridge** — a shared memory bought with growth — ignores it entirely; both selves can roll it. The third Bridge frays the severance for good, and the exclusion starts failing everywhere. That's the endgame.

PERSONAL EFFECTS (SIGNATURE ASSETS)

One per refiner, duly registered (or not): a single object the innie has hidden, found, or been given — *Irving's hand-drawn map of the severed floor, a contraband copy of The You You Are, a note in my own handwriting I don't remember writing*. Rated **d8**; it can be taken away, which is why it matters.

CHAPTER 03

INTAKE & CALIBRATION

“BRING YOUR WHOLE SELF TO WORK. WE WILL KEEP HALF.”

— INTAKE POSTER, SEVERED LOBBY

Every refiner begins with calibration. Complete each step in order, in ink. Work through them together, out loud — the table should know every outie's reason, the way coworkers slowly learn each other's. If you do not know an answer, your supervisor does.

STEP 1 · DEPARTMENT ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ MACRODATA REFINEMENT — sorting numbers that feel wrong
- ☐ OPTICS & DESIGN — printing the doctrine's posters; nursing old rivalries
- ☐ MAMMALIANS NURTURABLE — tending the goats; no one will tell you why
- ☐ CHOREOGRAPHY & MERRIMENT

Departments are flavor and access, not dice — but where you work decides what you can reach.

STEP 2 · NAME (INNIE) & OUTIE'S REASON FOR SEVERANCE

First name + last initial, Lumon style. Then your outie's reason for severance, in one sentence — grief, debt, a crime, coercion, belief. The table hears it.

STEP 3 · DISTINCTIONS (THREE, EACH **d8**)

One **outie**, one **innie**, one **free** — the self in question, the part of you neither Lumon nor your outie can fully name.

STEP 4 · THE NINE PRINCIPLES

All begin at **d8**; step **two** up to **d10** and **two** down to **d6**. Write a one-line statement for each. Your two **d10**s are the doctrine's hooks in you; your two **d6**s are where you're already slipping.

STEP 5 · RELATIONSHIPS (INSIDE / OUTSIDE · SEE CH. 2)

Rate per the spread in Chapter 2. Remember: only one set is awake at a time.

STEP 6 · PERSONAL EFFECT (**d8**)

Choose one object and say where it's hidden. If it is contraband, do not write that here.

STEP 7 · SECRET — FOR MANAGEMENT EYES ONLY

The one thing you are hiding from Lumon. (*I found a message from my outie. I think Ms. Casey is someone's wife. I know what the goats are for.*) This is campaign fuel; tell the GM, not necessarily the table. Fold along the dotted line.

Upon completion you will be issued **1 PP**. The Four Tempers (Chapter 4) all begin unstressed. Welcome to Lumon.

CHAPTER 04

CONDUCT & CORRECTION

“LUMON CORRECTS BECAUSE LUMON CARES.”

— OFFICE OF CULTURE & COMPLIANCE

The procedures in this chapter are therapeutic instruments, calibrated over decades. Cooperate with them and they will never need to be used twice.

TESTS, CONTESTS, AND PROPER CHANNELS

Default turn order is **Dramatic** — this is a game of glances, whispers, and break-room summons. Switch to **Action Order** only when the floor goes loud: a lockdown, a chase through the stairwell, the contingency going off.

Contests happen only against named GMCs — out-staring Milchick, lying to Cobel's face. You never roll against Lumon itself, the Board, or a department: those are systems, and systems are the **Doom Pool** and **Crisis Pools**.

THE NINE (DOOM POOL)

Lumon's doctrine, weaponized. The Doom Pool begins at **d6** **d6** and follows the standard rules — the GM adds a die on player opportunities (rolled 1s) — plus Severance-specific triggers:

- **Grows** when a refiner challenges a Principle (step up the lowest die), when a shift ends with the File unrefined, when the Overtime Contingency is used, and after every Compunction.
- **Spends** to interrupt a scene with Management, to inflict temper stress directly (*Cobel's smile doesn't reach her eyes — take Dread stress*), to summon a refiner to the Break Room or Wellness, to separate the party, or to reveal that a trusted routine was surveillance all along.
- **Escalation:** once the pool holds **d10**s, the Board takes notice — new directives, new cameras, a visit. At **d12** **d12**, the endgame unlocks: the testing floor doors open, or the Board convenes, and the season turns.

THE FILES (CRISIS POOLS) — REFINEMENT

Each MDR file — *Cold Harbor*, *Allentown*, *Siena* — is a **Crisis Pool** (e.g. Cold Harbor: three **d8**s). **Timed Test:** each refiner acts once, assembling a pool of a Principle (Wit, Nimbleness, and — Wiles) plus Distinctions and Relationships for teamwork. Effect dice step the File down; when the pool is gone, the file is complete — and something is revealed: a name, a face, a set of numbers that sorts toward someone you know.

nine tails. one for each principle. count them at the waffle party. — P.

Rolling a 1 while refining means the numbers got to you: take temper stress (GM's choice of Woe or Dread). This is the job's real wage.

THE FOUR TEMPERS (STRESS)

Kier taught that every worker carries four tempers to be tamed — **Woe** (melancholy, grief, inward despair), **Frolic** (levity, aimless indulgence), **Dread** (paralysis, apprehension), **Malice** (spite, defiance). Lumon calls them weaknesses. This handbook notes, for the record, that they are also the proof you're still human.

Each track steps **d6** → **d8** → **d10** → **d12**. At **d10** or higher the temper visibly warps your behavior — roleplay it; everyone at the table can see the crack.

COMPUNCTION

When a temper would step past **d12**, the refiner is **summoned to the Break Room**. Play the scene: the small room, the statement on the monitor, read aloud, read again, read until it sounds true. When it's over, the temper resets to **d6** — but the GM adds a **d8** to the Doom Pool and steps **down** one of the refiner's Principles. The doctrine corrects. It always collects its fee.

BREAK ROOM TERMINAL · STATEMENT 001 · READ ALOUD UNTIL SINCERE

Forgive me for the harm I have caused this world. None may atone for my actions but me, and only in me shall their stain live on. I am thankful to have been caught, my fall cut short by those with wizened hands. All I can be is sorry, and that is all I am. |

THE BREAK ROOM, WELLNESS, AND THE CARROT

The Break Room is the stick (above). **Wellness sessions** with Ms. Casey are the carrot: a completed wellness session steps **down** one temper of their choice — but Ms. Casey always asks one question she shouldn't be able to ask, about the outie's life. Answering truthfully creates an Asset for Management (the GM notes it); deflecting is a Contest. Nothing at Lumon is free.

I read it 214 times. I counted. — P.

Waffle parties and Music Dance Experiences work the same way at group scale: tempers step down across the department, and the Doom Pool grows a die. Joy, metered and priced.

APPROVED GENRES: Bawdy funk · Bouncy swing · Buoyant reggae · Defiant jazz · Effusive ska · Exalted choral · Exciting rap · Hootin tootin country · Lofty orchestra · Maximized rhythms · Playful punk · Reckless disco · Spooky ambient · Tearful emo · Thoughtful grunge

THE OVERTIME CONTINGENCY

Spend 1 PP and add a **d8** to the Doom Pool: **flip the active relationship set for one scene** — your outie wakes inside. Inside shuts down (the Limit: gain 1 PP, so the contingency costs you a Doom die, not plot

points); Outside comes online. Roll only outie-side traits — Outie distinction, free distinction, Outside relationships (and My Outie) — no Principles; the doctrine doesn't recognize this person. What the outie does with the body, the innie will never remember — unless someone was watching.

RESIGNATION REQUESTS

Filing one is a Test against the Doom Pool. Success means the request reaches your outie. Whether they honors it — whether they even open it — is a scene for an Outie Interlude, and the GM is under no obligation to be kind.

*it works. that's the
worst part. — P.*

FORM LUM-RES-002 · AVAILABLE FROM YOUR SUPERVISOR · ALLOW 6-8 WEEKS FOR PROCESSING · WITHDRAWALS OF
WITHDRAWALS ARE FINAL

CHAPTER 05

BEYOND THE BUILDING

“YOUR OUTIE MAINTAINS A LIFE BEYOND THESE WALLS SO THAT YOU DON’T
HAVE TO.”

— ORIENTATION DAY REMARKS

What follows is provided for context only. Do not romanticize it.

OUTIE INTERLUDES

Between shifts, each player frames a short scene as their **outie** — the parking lot, the apartment, the support group for the severed. Outies assemble pools from **Distinctions and Relationships only**: no Principles. The doctrine doesn't live outside the building. The Inside set is shut down out here — only Outside relationships (and My Outie) are on the table.

Discoveries made out here become **Assets the innie finds without knowing why**: a note in your own handwriting — don't trust the numbers (**d8**). The GM may also frame an interlude *against* the player: the outie considering quitting, the outie meeting someone reintegrated, the outie doing something the innie would hate them for. The two of you share a body and nothing else — act like it.

🦴 INSERTED PAGE — NOT PART OF THE OFFICIAL HANDBOOK

REINTEGRATION (GROWTH POOL)

Use the **Growth Pool**. At session's end, nominate moments when the selves bled through memory that surfaced mid-shift, an outie dreaming the fluorescent halls. Spend growth

Bridges: a shared memory both selves can roll, written as a trait both halves of the character sheet can reach (*The Lake House, Age Nine* — **d8**). Bridges are usable by innie *and* outie, Principles or no Principles. A Bridge ignores the Mutually Exclusive limit. The third Bridge frays the severance for good — that character's endgame has begun, and Lumon will do anything to stop it.

CONTRABAND

*they tore this page out
of every copy. I put it
back. — P.*

CHAPTER 06

OFFICE DIRECTORY

“YOU WILL FIND EVERYTHING YOU NEED ON THE SEVERED FLOOR.”

— ORIENTATION DAY REMARKS

Macrodata Refinement — your desks, your numbers, the eerie calm. **Optics & Design** — poster presses, old departmental grudges, surprisingly good coffee. **Mammalians Nurturable** — the goats; ask no questions. **The Break Room** — small, quiet, the statement on the table. **Wellness** — Ms. Casey's room, blue like a held breath. **The Perpetuity Wing** — Kier's statue, the paintings, the Eagan lineage watching. **The Exports Hall** — you do not go there. **The stairwell, the parking lot** — where the selves change places and neither remembers the handoff.

Harmony Cobel believes — truly, terribly believes. **Seth Milchick** enforces with a smile that has read the manual on smiles. **Ms. Casey** asks how your outie is doing, and waits. **The Board** never appears; when it speaks, the speaker crackles and everyone stands a little straighter. Outies drift through interludes like weather: grieving, indebted, devout, desperate — each one the reason the innie exists and the threat that could end them.

IN CASE OF FIRE, REMAIN AT YOUR WORKSTATION. THE NUMBERS MUST NOT BE LEFT UNSUPERVISED. · IN CASE OF FLOOD, SEE FIRE. · IN CASE OF DEFIANT JAZZ, CONTACT YOUR SUPERVISOR IMMEDIATELY.

APPENDIX A

STRUCTURAL COMPLIANCE

MANAGEMENT EYES ONLY

The following pages are restricted to Management personnel. If you are reading this without authorization, close the handbook and report to your supervisor. Your supervisor has been notified regardless.

TRAIT & TRAIT MODS

- Distinctions (outie / innie / free structure)
- Values — as **The Nine Principles**, rated, with statements
- Relationships — two **Mutually Exclusive** sets (**Inside / Outside**); *My Outie* never shuts down
- Signature Assets
- Trait Statements (on Principles)

CHARACTER CREATION

- Scratch-Built (7 steps) — see **Chapter 03: Intake & Calibration**

GROWING CHARACTERS

- Growth Pool — as **Reintegration** (Bridges)

CONFLICTS & CONFLICT MODS

- Tests; Timed Tests (refinement shifts)
- Contests — vs. named GMCs only
- Crisis Pools — as **The Files**

- Doom Pool — as **The Nine**

- Dramatic Order (default); Action Order

*this page is for them.
read it anyway. — P.*

DICE & ROLLING

- Static Difficulty (routine work)

COMPLICATIONS

- Complications (standard)
- Stress — as **The Four Tempers**, with **Compunction** replacing stress-out

PLOT POINTS

- Starting PP: 1

GMCs

- Major: Harmony Cobel, Seth Milchick
- Minor: Ms. Casey, outies, department heads
- Faction: The Board (never seen; speaks through a speaker)
- Location GMCs: the severed floor itself

APPENDIX B

PERSONNEL FILES

“EXEMPLARY CONDUCT WILL BE RECOGNIZED. ALL OTHER CONDUCT WILL
ALSO BE RECOGNIZED.”

— OFFICE OF CULTURE & COMPLIANCE

The refiners below have been recognized for exemplary conduct. Emulate them.

PERSONNEL FILE · REF-MDR-0117 · CLEARANCE: SEVERED FLOOR

SOL W.

MACRODATA REFINEMENT · INNIE, SECOND YEAR

OUTIE'S REASON

Severed after the ferry accident he blames himself for — he wanted eight hours a day without remembering.

**DISTINCTIONS**

My Outie Drowned Someone (outie) d8 · *The Friendliest Refiner on the Floor* (innie) d8 · *I Laugh When I Shouldn't* (free) d8

PRINCIPLES

Cheer d10 *"Grief is just cheer, misfiled."* · Benevolence d10 · Wiles d6 · Probity d6 · all others d8

RELATIONSHIPS

Inside: Ana R. d10 · Ms. Casey d8 · rest d6 — **Outside:** d8 · rest d6 — **My Outie** d8 (never shuts down)

PERSONAL EFFECT

A ferry token in my desk drawer, warm some mornings d8

SECRET

His outie has started leaving him messages — and the latest one says *don't refine Cold Harbor*.

*he reminds me of
someone I used to know.
be kind to him. — P.*

PERSONNEL FILE · REF-MDR-0089 · CLEARANCE: SEVERED FLOOR

ANA R.

MACRODATA REFINEMENT · INNIE, FOURTH YEAR

OUTIE'S REASON

A Kier devotee who severed as an act of faith — she tithed her workday to the founder.



DISTINCTIONS

My Outie Tithes to Kier (outie) d8 · *I Ask the Questions No One Asks* (innie)

d8 · *A Mind Like a Snare* (free) d8

PRINCIPLES

Humility d10 *"I am the smallest thing in Kier's house."* · Probity d10 · Cheer d6 · Verve d6 · all others d8

RELATIONSHIPS

Inside: Sol W. d10 · Seth Milchick d8 (fear counts) · rest d6 — **Outside:** d8 · rest d6 — My Outie d8 (never shuts down)

PERSONAL EFFECT

Pages of The You You Are copied by hand, hidden in a ceiling tile d8

SECRET

She has started keeping a list of everything Wellness asks about her outie — and the list is getting long.

FINAL SECTION

ORIENTATION DAY

“YOUR FIRST DAY FOLLOWS THE SCHEDULE BELOW. DEVIATIONS WILL BE NOTED.”

— OFFICE OF CULTURE & COMPLIANCE

Situation. A new file, **COLD HARBOR**, has landed in Macrodata Refinement with a quota and a deadline. Management announces a "wellness initiative": mandatory sessions for all refiners. And Petra D., the department's senior refiner, hasn't come back from the Break Room — it's been three days, and her desk is exactly as she left it. The refiners are the ones left holding the file.

Reveals (one per refiner, plus the floor):

- *For the new hire:* the orientation video addresses you by a name that isn't yours — then corrects itself. No one else reacts.
- *For the veteran:* the numbers in Cold Harbor sort toward a face you almost recognize. Roll Woe or look away.
- *For the believer:* Ms. Casey asks about your outie's childhood home. You never told her your outie had one.
- *For the floor:* the Break Room door is warm to the touch, like something in there has been breathing.

Opening scenes:

1. **The video.** Kier's voice over the Perpetuity Wing tour: the Nine Principles recited like scripture. Each player states which principle their innie clings to — and which one already itches.
2. **First shift.** Cold Harbor on the screens (Crisis Pool, three **d8**s). Refine. The numbers feel wrong for exactly one refiner — their choice which, and why.
3. **The summons.** Split the party: one refiner to Wellness (Ms. Casey, one impossible question), one to the Break Room (Petra D.'s chair is still warm). The rest watch the hallway and learn what surveillance feels like.

*on my first day the video
said my name too. I
never told them it did. —
P.*



PRAISE KIER

REMEDIUM HOMINIBUS

"A Cure for Mankind"

LUMON INDUSTRIES · KIER, PE

DOC. NO. LUM-MDR-0047 · REV. 12